What Mom's Week Rests On

A short guide to gaps, backups and knowing when to look again.

Mom's arrangement works. A neighbor drives her to appointments, your brother handles the bills, and you call every evening. An arrangement like that is easy to live inside and hard to describe. Ask three relatives who would drive if the neighbor were away, and you may hear three different names.

This guide explains four ideas that put a working arrangement on paper: today and later, who said what, what she gets help with beside who helps, and when to look again. It explains. It doesn't assess.

Today and later are two lists

The National Institute on Aging says the conversation about sharing care is most productive when there is not an emergency. It describes a calm discussion about what kind of care is wanted and needed in the present, and what might be needed in the future. A calm week, in other words, is a good week for this. [1]

The present and the future are worth keeping apart. Something that isn't covered today is a present gap: a task nobody does yet, or one that gets done only some of the time. Something that might come up later is a future question: who would drive if the neighbor's schedule changed. The first is something the family can talk about now. The second is something to keep in view.

- Write “today” or “later” beside each line.
- A “later” line doesn't need an answer yet. It needs to be written where the family can find it.

One place, with who said it

Start with Mom. The CDC's guide to care plans says to begin the conversation with the person herself, and suggests talking with others who regularly interact with her for anything she can't supply. In this family that's the neighbor, your brother and you, and each of you knows a different part of her week. [3]

The National Institute on Aging suggests compiling a notebook with the details of a person's care, contact numbers and other pertinent details. One notebook that everyone adds to is enough. [1]

Beside each note, write who said it and when. And notice when several people are passing along one account. If your brother says the neighbor is glad to keep driving, and he heard that from Mom, who heard it in the driveway last spring, that is one account from last spring. It isn't three.

- “Not sure” is a real entry. Leave it on the page and don't fill it with a guess.

What she gets help with, beside who helps

Much of what holds a week together doesn't look like care. The National Institute on Aging says family, friends and neighbors are the biggest source of help for many older people: driving to appointments, helping with errands and chores, or keeping company. By the federal Administration for Community Living's figure, about 80 percent of care at home is provided by unpaid caregivers. [2] [4]

For going through the week in order, the National Institute on Aging's list of help at home is a plain place to start: personal care, household chores, meals, money management, health care, transportation and safety. For each one, write who does it, and "Mom, on her own" is a complete answer. Then write who else could. [2]

A backup is the same comparison, one step out. The Family Caregiver Alliance's first step is to think about who would be the most likely person to help, and to talk with them about what might be needed and their willingness to step in. Until someone has had that conversation, the entry beside the name is "assumed." The same page tells caregivers without a backup plan that they are not alone, and that many handle everything themselves, so finding a few "assumed" entries on your list is ordinary. [6]

Two things are easy to leave off. One is the helpers themselves: the National Institute on Aging says no one can be expected to do everything, and asks caregivers to be realistic about how much they can do and what they are willing to do. The other is the part of the week that isn't a task. The same institute describes meaningful activities as those that create a sense of purpose in daily life, such as hobbies, volunteer activities, or time with family and friends. Who Mom sees and what she looks forward to belong on the page with the driving and the bills. [1] [5]

- Ask each helper what their part takes in an ordinary week. The person doing it is the one who knows.
- What Mom enjoys is hers to say. Write what she tells you, and keep it apart from what the family would choose for her.

Plain words, and when to look again

Write each open line as what happens, not as what's wrong. "Only the neighbor has the appointment card" is a note anyone in the family can read, Mom included. The National Institute on Aging gives the same advice for conversation: mention a worry without sounding critical. [7]

Some lines will be questions the family can't settle by asking each other. A question about her health goes to her doctor. A question about what her support has to cover goes to your care consultant. Writing the question down is your part.

Then note when to look again. The sources agree in general terms. The CDC suggests updating a written care plan every year, or more often when health or medicines change. The National Institute on Aging says these arrangements may need revising as the person's needs and family members' availability change. The Family Caregiver Alliance says families should meet again when the caregiving situation, or something in a family member's own life, changes. [3] [1] [8]

- Write the changes you'd actually notice: a helper's new job, a move, a change in Mom's health or medicines.
- A change on that list means reread the page. It doesn't say anything has gone wrong, and it doesn't say what to do.

What this means for your family

- "It works" becomes a page: who does what, who else could, and what has been agreed.
- "Not covered today" and "might come up later" sit in separate lists, so the family can talk about the first and keep the second in view.
- A backup is "agreed" once the person has been asked and has said yes. Until then it's "assumed," and that is simply something to ask about.
- Your part is to describe, with names and dates. Whether Mom's arrangement is enough is a question for her and the professionals who know her, and your page is what you bring to it.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say whether Mom's arrangement is enough, predict when anything will change, or suggest adding or changing any help. What the public sources say is marked with their numbers. The advice about what to write down, and about keeping today and later apart, is ours.

Ready for the next step?

You can now tell something that isn't covered today from something that might come up later, and an agreed backup from an assumed one. The care interview goes through every area of Mom's daily life in turn, including the ones that are fine today, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
2. National Institute on Aging, Aging in Place: Growing Older at Home
3. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan
4. Administration for Community Living, Who Will Provide Your Care?
5. National Institute on Aging, Participating in Activities You Enjoy As You Age
6. Family Caregiver Alliance, Smart Caregiving by FCA: Backup Planning
7. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
8. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting